Dr. Edward Ali Nahim (also referred to as Dr. Naim in some contexts) was a pioneering psychiatrist in Sierra Leone, widely recognized as the first and long-time sole consultant psychiatrist in the country.

🧠 Dr. Edward Ali Nahim: Sierra Leone's Pioneering Psychiatrist

Profile Overview

Attribute	Details
Full Name	Dr. Edward Ali Nahim (also spelled Nehme originally)
Date of Birth	December 12, 1944
Place of Birth	Port Loko, Northern Sierra Leone
Date of Death	January 1, 2024 (at age 79)
Cause of Death	Heart attack
Education	MD from Kharkov Medical Institute, Ukraine (USSR); Diploma in Psychological Medicine, UK
Key Role	Sierra Leone's first and only psychiatrist for decades
Awards	Commander of the Order of Rokel (2004)

🌱 Early Life and Education

Dr. Edward Ali Nahim was born on **December 12, 1944**, in **Port Loko, Northern Sierra Leone**, into a mixed Middle Eastern and African heritage family. His father was of Lebanese ancestry (Abdallah Nehme), and his mother (Amie Kamara) was from the Temne tribe. His surname was changed from "Nehme" to "Nahim" during his enrolment at Bo School due to an error by the English headmaster.

He completed his primary education at the **Church of England School in Pepel** and attended **Schlenker Secondary School** in Port Loko for his O-levels. He later completed his A-levels at **Bo Government Secondary School**, where he excelled in sciences, achieving the best Chemistry A-level result in West Africa that year.

In 1965, he received a scholarship to study medicine in the **Soviet Union (Ukraine)**, graduating with an MD in 1972 from the Kharkov Medical Institute. During his studies, he married Larisa Doudnikova, a Ukrainian woman, and they had two daughters together.

💼 Career and Contributions

- **Pioneering Psychiatry in Sierra Leone**: Upon returning to Sierra Leone in 1972, Dr. Nahim began working as a general practitioner with the Ministry of Health. Initially focused on pediatrics, he was persuaded by the Chief Medical Officer, Dr. Marcella Davies, to specialize in psychiatry due to the absence of qualified psychiatrists in the country. He obtained a **Diploma in Psychological Medicine** from the Institute of Psychiatry, Psychology & Neuroscience at King's College London in 1978 and became a member of the **Royal College of Psychiatry** in the UK.
- **Leadership at Sierra Leone Psychiatric Hospital**: Dr. Nahim served as the **sole consultant psychiatrist** at the Sierra Leone Psychiatric Hospital (formerly Kissy Mental Hospital) for over 40 years, starting in 1981. He was instrumental in introducing psychiatry curricula at the **College of Medicine and Allied Health Sciences (COMAHS)** and lectured there until his retirement in 2023.
- **Crisis and Humanitarian Work**: During Sierra Leone's **civil war (1991–2002)** and the **Ebola outbreak (2014–2016)**, Dr. Nahim played a critical role in providing mental health care to affected populations, including **child soldiers** and trauma victims. He facilitated demobilization, rehabilitation, and job reintegration programs. He also contributed to WHO initiatives, such as developing guidelines for mental health needs in conflict-affected populations.
- **Advocacy and Challenges**: As the only psychiatrist in a country of over 7 million people, Dr. Nahim faced significant challenges, including **stigma against mental health**, lack of funding, and insufficient staff. He often treated patients for free and advocated for more government support, training for psychiatric nurses, and better facilities.

📊 Key Statistics and Impact

- **Patient Load**: Over his career, Dr. Nahim treated an estimated:

    - 100,000 patients with drug abuse issues.
    - 40,000 with epilepsy or mental disabilities.
    - 20,000 with post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD).
    - 100,000 with depression and schizophrenia.
- **Mental Health Survey**: WHO estimates indicated that **400,000 Sierra Leoneans** suffered from mental health issues post-civil war, with less than 1% receiving treatment. More recent surveys suggest even higher numbers.

🏆 Legacy and Recognition

- **Awards**: In 2004, Dr. Nahim was awarded the **Commander of the Order of Rokel (COR)**, Sierra Leone's second-highest civilian honor, for his contributions to mental health.
- **Global Influence**: He contributed to WHO programs and was known for his resilience and dedication despite limited resources.
- **Personal Sacrifice**: Dr. Nahim often used his own time and money to support patients and address systemic challenges in mental health care.

💔 Death and Remembrance

Dr. Nahim passed away on **January 1, 2024**, following a heart attack. His funeral was held in Pepel on January 5, 2024. He is survived by his wife, two daughters (Diana Nahim and Angelique Doudnikova), and multiple siblings.

Dr. Nahim's legacy as a pioneering psychiatrist and advocate for mental health in Sierra Leone continues to inspire future generations. His work highlighted the critical need for mental health services in post-conflict and resource-limited settings